



Hamilton School for
Classical and Civic Education
UNIVERSITY *of* FLORIDA

Politics Without Romance

The General Will and the Paradoxes of Voting
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Should the government fight disinformation online?

Wherever you say “the government” or “the State,” write instead:

the politicians you actually know,
elected by voters and lobbied by interest groups
that actually exist.

Do you still believe it?



The store



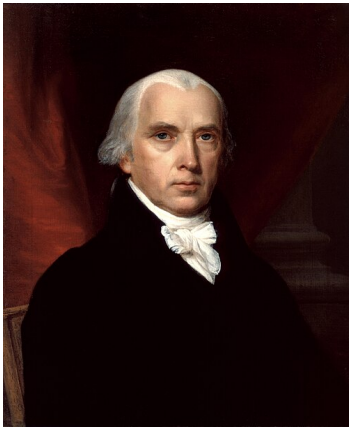
The voting booth

Buchanan, "Public Choice: Politics Without Romance," 2003

"Public choice, as an inclusive research programme, incorporates the presumption that persons do not readily become economic eunuchs as they shift from market to political participation. Those who respond predictably to ordinary incentives in the marketplace do not fail to respond at all when they act as citizens."



James M. Buchanan
(1919–2013)



James Madison
(1751–1836)

UF | What do “the people” want?



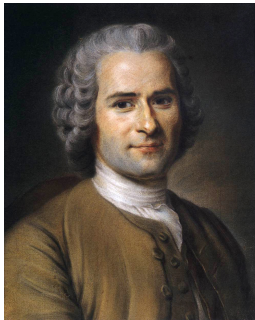
The Landsgemeinde of Glarus, Switzerland: voters raise their voting cards.

The **general will** is what the people as a whole want for their common good, as distinct from what each person wants for himself (Rousseau, *The Social Contract*, 1762).

Related terms: the common good, the public interest, the general welfare, the will of the people.

Jean-Jacques Rousseau, *The Social Contract*, 1762

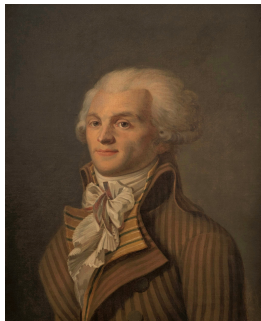
"[W]hat the people is asked is not exactly whether it approves or rejects the proposal, but whether it is in conformity with the general will, which is their will. Each man, in giving his vote, states his opinion on that point; and the general will is found by counting votes. When therefore the opinion that is contrary to my own prevails, this proves neither more nor less than that I was mistaken, and that what I thought to be the general will was not so."



Jean-Jacques Rousseau
(1712–1778)

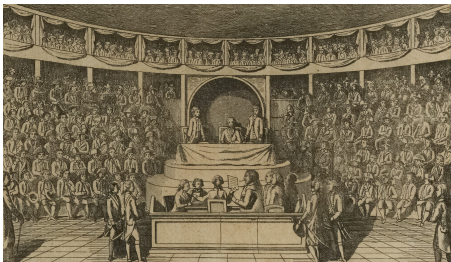
Maximilien Robespierre, speech on the Constitution, 1793

“Government is established to make the general will respected; but men who govern have individual wills, and every will seeks to dominate.”



Maximilien Robespierre
(1758–1794)

UF | One center or many bodies?



Paris, 1792



Washington

Turgot, letter to Richard Price, 1778

“Instead of collecting all authority into one center, that of the nation, they have established different bodies; a body of representatives, a council, and a Governour, because there is in England a House of Commons, a House of Lords, and a King.—They endeavour to balance these different powers, as if this equilibrium, which in England may be a necessary check to the enormous influence of royalty, could be of any use in Republics founded upon the equality of all the Citizens [. . .]”



A.-R.-J. Turgot
(1727–1781)



Constitution of the United States, Preamble, 1787

"We the People of the United States, in Order to form a more perfect Union, establish Justice, insure domestic Tranquility, provide for the common defence, promote the general Welfare, and secure the Blessings of Liberty to ourselves and our Posterity, do ordain and establish this Constitution for the United States of America."

	1st	2nd	3rd
Voter 1	A	B	C
Voter 2	B	C	A
Voter 3	C	A	B

	1st	2nd	3rd
Voter 1	A	B	C
Voter 2	B	C	A
Voter 3	C	A	B

- ▶ A beats B, 2 to 1 (voters 1 and 3).
- ▶ B beats C, 2 to 1 (voters 1 and 2).
- ▶ C beats A, 2 to 1 (voters 2 and 3).

⇒ No option beats both others. Each voter's ranking is consistent, but **the majority's ranking goes in a circle**: a majority cycle.

The agenda is the order of the votes. Two options meet first; the winner then meets the option held back.

	1st	2nd	3rd
Voter 1	A	B	C
Voter 2	B	C	A
Voter 3	C	A	B

- ▶ A vs. B first $\Rightarrow$ A. Then A vs. C $\Rightarrow$ **C wins.**
- ▶ B vs. C first $\Rightarrow$ B. Then B vs. A $\Rightarrow$ **A wins.**
- ▶ A vs. C first $\Rightarrow$ C. Then C vs. B $\Rightarrow$ **B wins.**

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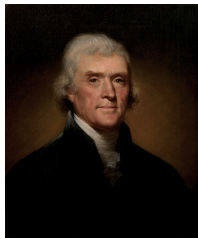
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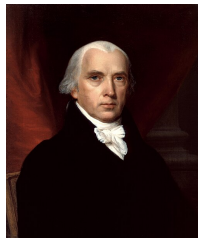
$\Rightarrow$ The option held back wins every time: whoever sets the agenda picks the winner.

UF | Did the Founders know Condorcet?

- ▶ Jefferson: in Paris from 1784, US minister to France 1785–1789, and a close friend of Condorcet.
- ▶ Jefferson sent Madison books by Condorcet; in 1788 Madison forwarded the 1785 *Essai* to Edmund Randolph.
- ▶ McLean and Urken (1992): neither Jefferson nor Madison understood Condorcet's theory of social choice.



Thomas Jefferson
(1743–1826)



James Madison
(1751–1836)

Source: McLean, Iain and Arnold B. Urken. (1992). "Did Jefferson or Madison Understand Condorcet's Theory of Social Choice?" *Public Choice* 73(4), 445–457.

- ▶ Rousseau, *The Social Contract*: the general will “is found by counting votes.”
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- ▶ Rousseau, *The Social Contract*: the general will “is found by counting votes.”
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Whichever option is chosen, **a majority prefers another.**

Majority rule cycles. Is there a better way to count?

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Kenneth Arrow (1951) proved that, with three or more options, **no voting rule** can turn every set of rankings into a cycle-free group ranking and meet a few mild conditions, unless one voter always prevails.



Kenneth Arrow
(1921–2017)

A voting rule should:

- ▶ Work whatever rankings the voters happen to have.
- ▶ Rank A above B whenever every voter does (unanimity).
- ▶ Decide A vs. B only from how voters rank A against B, whatever they think of C (independence of irrelevant alternatives).
- ▶ Give no single voter the last word (no dictator).

⇒ With three or more options, no rule meets all four and always delivers a cycle-free group ranking.

Counting votes does not find the general will.

The voting rule and the agenda **make** one.

Schumpeter, *Capitalism, Socialism and Democracy*, 1942

"[T]he typical citizen drops down to a lower level of mental performance as soon as he enters the political field. He argues and analyzes in a way which he would readily recognize as infantile within the sphere of his real interests. He becomes a primitive again."



Joseph A. Schumpeter
(1883–1950)

H. L. Mencken, *A Little Book in C Major*, 1916

“Democracy is the theory that the common people know what they want, and deserve to get it good and hard.”



H. L. Mencken
(1880–1956)

UF | Why wait in this line?



Philadelphia, Election Day 2016.

Anthony Downs (1957): vote if the benefit you expect from voting beats its cost.

$$p \times B > C$$

- ▶ p : the chance that your vote decides the election.
- ▶ B : what your side's win is worth to you.
- ▶ C : the cost of voting (time, gas, a rainy day).

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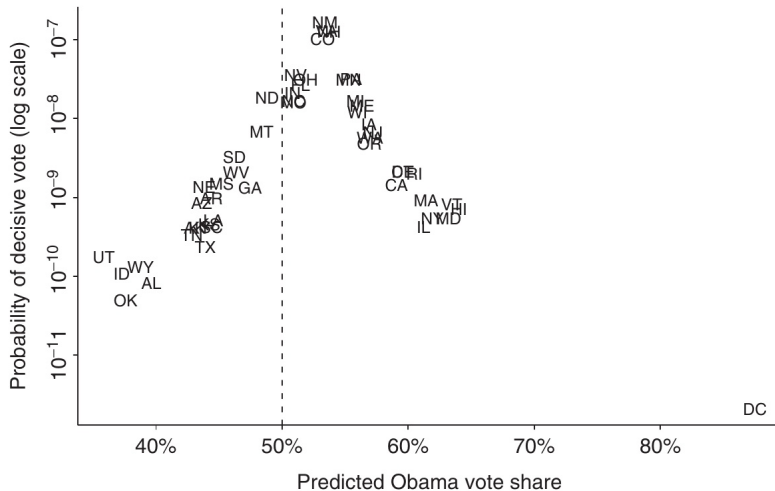
- ▶ p : the chance that your vote decides the election.
- ▶ B : what your side's win is worth to you.
- ▶ C : the cost of voting (time, gas, a rainy day).

B can be large. p is the problem.

Event	Odds
US House races, 1898–1992, decided by one vote	1 of 16,577
Your vote decides the 2008 presidential election (US average)	1 in 60 million
In the closest states (New Mexico, Virginia, New Hampshire, Colorado)	about 1 in 10 million
26 coin flips, all heads	1 in 67 million
Powerball jackpot	1 in 292 million

Source: Mulligan, Casey B. and Charles G. Hunter. (2003). "The Empirical Frequency of a Pivotal Vote," *Public Choice* 116(1–2), 31–54; Gelman, Andrew, Nate Silver and Aaron Edlin. (2012). "What Is the Probability Your Vote Will Make a Difference?" *Economic Inquiry* 50(2), 321–326.





Note: chance that one vote decides the 2008 presidential election, by state (log scale), against Obama's predicted share of the state's vote. Gelman, Silver and Edlin (2012), *Economic Inquiry* 50(2), Fig. 2B.

- ▶ For almost everyone, $p \times B$ is smaller than $C \Rightarrow$ on this arithmetic, almost nobody should vote.
- ▶ Yet about 64% of eligible Americans voted in 2024.

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Why?

Source: McDonald, Michael P. (2026). "2024 General Election Turnout," UF Election Lab, estimates as of 2 March 2026.

If you care about everyone the election affects, B is the stakes for hundreds of millions of people $\Rightarrow p \times B$ can beat C (Edlin, Gelman and Kaplan, 2007).

Gelman, Silver and Edlin, "What Is the Probability Your Vote Will Make a Difference?," 2012

"[A] vote is like a lottery ticket with a 1 in 10 million chance of winning, but the payoff is the chance to change national policy and improve (one hopes) the lives of hundreds of millions [...]"

Riker and Ordeshook (1968) add a reward for the act of voting itself:

$$p \times B + D > C$$

- ▶ D : the satisfaction of doing your duty, expressing who you are, being seen to vote.
- ▶ 1952–60: 87% of citizens with a high sense of duty said they voted, vs. 51% with a low one.

Source: Riker, William H. and Peter C. Ordeshook. (1968). "A Theory of the Calculus of Voting," *American Political Science Review* 62(1), 25–42, Table 3.

- ▶ Canada, 1993 federal election: university students heard a 10-minute presentation on the paradox of voting.

- ▶ Canada, 1993 federal election: university students heard a 10-minute presentation on the paradox of voting.
- ▶ Their turnout fell by 7 percentage points, mostly because the lecture weakened their sense of duty.

Source: Blais, André and Robert Young. (1999). "Why Do People Vote? An Experiment in Rationality," *Public Choice* 99(1–2), 39–55.

Dear Registered Voter:

WHAT IF YOUR NEIGHBORS KNEW WHETHER YOU VOTED?

Why do so many people fail to vote? We've been talking about the problem for years, but it only seems to get worse. This year, we're taking a new approach. We're sending this mailing to you and your neighbors to publicize who does and does not vote.

The chart shows the names of some of your neighbors, showing which have voted in the past. After the August 8 election, we intend to mail an updated chart. You and your neighbors will all know who voted and who did not.

DO YOUR CIVIC DUTY — VOTE!

MAPLE DR	Aug 04	Nov 04	Aug 06
9995 JOSEPH JAMES SMITH	Voted	Voted	_____
9995 JENNIFER KAY SMITH		Voted	_____
9997 RICHARD B JACKSON		Voted	_____
9999 KATHY MARIE JACKSON		Voted	_____
9999 BRIAN JOSEPH JACKSON		Voted	_____
9991 JENNIFER KAY THOMPSON		Voted	_____
9991 BOB R THOMPSON		Voted	_____

The Neighbors letter, Michigan, August 2006 (Gerber, Green and Larimer, 2008).

Michigan, August 2006 primary: households got one of four letters, or none.

Letter	Turnout
No letter	29.7%
Civic duty letter	31.5%
Neighbors letter: your neighbors will see whether you voted	37.8%

Source: Gerber, Alan S., Donald P. Green and Christopher W. Larimer. (2008). "Social Pressure and Voter Turnout: Evidence from a Large-Scale Field Experiment," *American Political Science Review* 102(1), 33–48, Table 2.

UF | Who says “we won”?



Expressive voting: voting to show who you are and whom you back, not to change who wins.

Brennan and Lomasky (1993) compare the voter to a sports fan:

Geoffrey Brennan and Loren Lomasky, *Democracy and Decision*, 1993

“But even the most enthusiastic partisan does not and cannot believe that his cheering brings about the outcome for which his cheering is expressed.”

UF | Why do celebrities post their votes?



I spoke to @vmagazine about why I'll be voting for Joe Biden for president. So apt that it's come out on the night of the VP debate. Gonna be watching and supporting @KamalaHarris by yelling at the tv a lot. And I also have custom cookies 🍪👉👈

@inezandvinoodh



9:23 PM · Oct 7, 2020

14K 57K 325K 1.5K

Taylor Swift, 2020

EmRata Is a Hot Girl for Zohran, Too

By EJ Dickson

12:23 P.M.



A still from Emily Ratajowski's Zohran Mamdani endorsement post. Photo: @emrata/Instagram

With New York progressives like Letitia James and Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez coming out in full force to endorse Zohran Mamdani, it was inevitable that at some point the celebrities would follow suit. On Tuesday morning, New York's most ubiquitous dog mom Emily Ratajowski, posted her own video endorsing Mamdani, sporting a Hot Girls for Zohran T-shirt with Mamdani in the background.

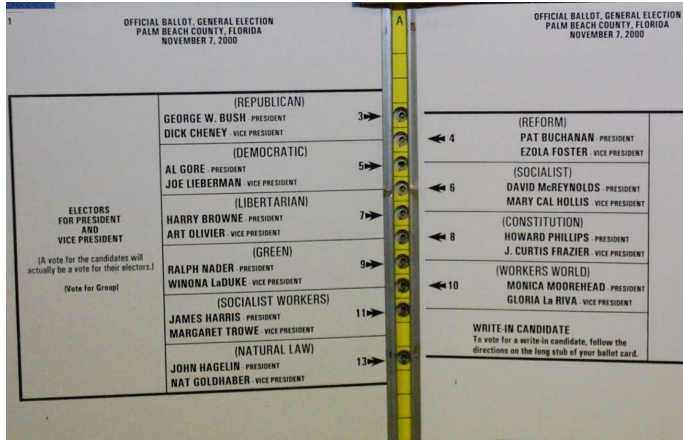
Emily Ratajowski for Zohran Mamdani, 2025

- ▶ A ballot is secret; a post about it has an audience $\Rightarrow$ social media raises D , not p .
- ▶ 10 Sept. 2024: Swift's endorsement of Kamala Harris sent 405,999 visitors to [vote.gov](https://www.vote.gov) within 24 hours (GSA).

Source: Becket, Stefan. (2024). "Taylor Swift drove 405,999 visitors to [vote.gov](https://www.vote.gov) in 24 hours after Kamala Harris endorsement," *CBS News*, 11 September.



Why don't more people vote for third parties?



Palm Beach County, Florida, November 2000.

A purely expressive voter backs her favorite even when it cannot win.

- ▶ **Strategic voting**: in Germany, about a third of voters whose favorite cannot win switch to one who can, as if their vote might count.
- ▶ **Closeness**: when a published poll showed a Swiss referendum was close, more people voted right away.

Source: Spenkuch, Jörg L. (2013). "On the Extent of Strategic Voting," MPRA Paper 50198; Bursztyn, Leonardo, Davide Cantoni, Patricia Funk, Felix Schönenberger and Noam Yuchtman. (2024). "Identifying the Effect of Election Closeness on Voter Turnout: Evidence from Swiss Referenda," *Journal of the European Economic Association* 22(2), 876–914.

- ▶ In US field experiments, telling voters the race will be close barely moves turnout.
- ▶ Florida, 2000: 97,488 people voted for Nader in a state decided by 537 votes.

Source: Spenkuch (2013); Gerber, Alan, Mitchell Hoffman, John Morgan and Collin Raymond. (2020). "One in a Million: Field Experiments on Perceived Closeness of the Election and Voter Turnout," *AJ: Applied Economics* 12(3), 287–325.

Rational ignorance: choosing not to learn about politics, because learning costs more than your one vote can pay back.

- ▶ Downs (1957): learning costs hours, but it pays off only if your vote decides the election, which happens with chance p .
- ▶ You spend weeks researching a \$1,000 phone and minutes on a candidate who will manage billions in taxes. At the store, your choice is decisive.

- ▶ 2010: 59% of Americans could name the Vice President (Pew).
- ▶ 2026: only 65% could name the three branches of government (Annenberg).
- ▶ 2025: the average guess for foreign aid's share of the federal budget was 26%; the actual share is about 1% (KFF).

Source: Pew Forum on Religion & Public Life. (2010). *U.S. Religious Knowledge Survey*, p. 34; Annenberg Public Policy Center. (2026). *Annenberg Constitution Day Civics Survey*; KFF. (2025). "KFF Health Tracking Poll February 2025: The Public's Views on Global Health and USAID."



- ▶ **The irresponsible voter** (Brennan and Buchanan, 1984): your vote almost never decides $\Rightarrow$ voting for what feels good, not for what you would choose if you had to live with it, costs you almost nothing.
- ▶ Imagine a candidate you think would hurt the country, but who voices your anger.
- ▶ **The noble voter**: the same low cost frees you to vote your ideals. Which one wins is an open question.